

Cancer drug treatments explained

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Cancer drug treatments are called systemic anti-cancer therapy (SACT). They include chemotherapy, targeted therapy, immunotherapy and hormonal therapy.

How cancer drug treatments are given

Cancer drug treatments can be given in different ways depending on the drug, the type of cancer and your treatment plan.

Chemotherapy

Chemotherapy drugs are used to treat many different types of cancer. They are most commonly given into a vein or as tablets or capsules.

Targeted therapy

Targeted therapies are drugs that find and attack cancer cells. There are many different types of targeted therapy.

Immunotherapy

Immunotherapy is used to treat many different types of cancer. Find out more about having immunotherapy treatment and what to expect.

Hormonal therapies

Some cancers depend on hormones to grow. Find out about different hormonal therapies and how they work.

Cannulas

A cannula is a short, thin tube that is put into a vein in your arm or the back of your hand for treatment. It will be removed before you go home.

Central lines

A central line is a long, thin hollow tube. It is put into a vein in your chest and used to give chemotherapy and other drugs.

PICC lines

A PICC line is a long, thin, flexible tube which is put into the arm to give chemotherapy and other treatments.

Implantable ports

An implantable port is a tube with a rubber disc at the end. It sits under the skin and can be used to give chemotherapy or other treatments.

How we can help



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.



Online Community ask the expert

Join our free cancer forums and chat anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and you can use the Ask an Expert section to get information and support from our experienced professionals.